



A WOMAN walks by television cameras and lights in front of the Reiners' home in Brentwood on Monday.

TRANS CARE TARGET OF BILL

House passes GOP measures to end gender-affirming treatment for minors.

By Kevin Rector

The Trump administration and House Republicans advanced measures this week to end gender-affirming care for transgender children and some young adults, drawing outrage and resistance from LGBTQ+ advocacy organizations, families with transgender kids, medical providers and some of California's liberal leaders.

The latest efforts — which seek to ban such care nationwide, strip funding from hospitals that provide it and punish doctors and parents who perform or support it — follow earlier executive orders from President Trump and work by the Justice Department to rein in such care.

Many hospitals, including in California, already curtailed such care or shuttered their gender-affirming care programs as a result.

Abigail Jones, a 17-year-old transgender activist from Riverside, called the moves “ridiculous” and dangerous, as such care “saves lives.”

She also called them a purely political act by Republicans intent on making transgender people into a “monster” to rally their base against, and one that is “going to backfire on them because they're not focusing on what the people want,” such as affordability and lower healthcare costs.

On Wednesday the House passed a sweeping ban on gender-affirming care for youth that was put forward by Rep. Marjorie Taylor Greene (R-Ga.), largely along party lines.

The bill — which faces a tougher road in the U.S. Senate — bars already rare gender-affirming surgeries but also more common treatments such as hormone therapies and puberty blockers for anyone under 18. It also calls for the criminal prosecution of doctors and other healthcare workers who provide such care, and for penalties for parents who facilitate or consent to it being performed on their children.

[See Healthcare, A7]

Reiner slayings rattle small-town Brentwood

Celebrity enclave gets unwanted spotlight as it mourns

By Salvador Hernandez

Sandwiched between Bel-Air and Santa Monica, the tony Los Angeles neighborhood of Brentwood has long been home to more than its fair share of industry captains, actors, directors, musicians, media moguls and professional athletes.

But despite its tall hedges, multimillion-dollar homes and marquee names, residents say Brentwood feels like a small town. It's not that unusual to see a famous face at the local coffeehouse or supermarket, or power-walking along San Vicente Boulevard.

“You could also be walking around the Country Mart and, hey, there's Dustin Hoffman. It happens,” said Jeff Hall, founder of Brentwood News and a Brentwood resident for 35 years.

Now, residents here are taking the shocking killings of Hollywood legend Rob Reiner and his photographer wife, Michele, hard. Reiner was a popular figure

among a legion of fans, as well as those who called him a neighbor. Compounding the pain has been the arrest of their son Nick, who lived in the Reiners' guesthouse and grew up in the area.

Since news of the killing broke Sunday, the international media have descended on the community. The streets are dotted with TV trucks beaming live coverage and reporters looking to make sense of the violence.

This too is something Brentwood is familiar with. In 1962, the death of Marilyn Monroe brought notoriety. Then, 31 years ago, Brentwood was under siege for months by one of the most sensational killings of all time. Nicole Brown Simpson and her friend Ron Goldman were found stabbed to death outside Brown's condo on Bundy Drive. Days later, O.J. Simpson was arrested after leading police on an infamous “slow-speed chase” from Orange County to the gates of his Brentwood estate on Rockingham Avenue.

The global media camped out, and it

[See Brentwood, A7]



A GOVERNMENT agent in Michoacán tours a scene of organized crime violence.

In Mexico, ‘invisible crime’ of extortion exacts heavy toll

By Patrick J. McDonnell and Cecilia Sánchez Vidal

MEXICO CITY — A shop owner facing threats shutters the clothing store that had been in his family for generations.

A leader of a citrus growers association is kidnapped and killed after refusing mob demands for a cut of profits.

Enraged peasant farmers fed up with paying graft turn on cartel thugs in a bloody showdown.

In Mexico, these real-life incidents all arise from a sig-

nature offense: extortion.

Gang shakedowns are rampant in Mexico, victimizing untold numbers — street vendors and taxi drivers, restaurateurs and farmers, factory owners and mine operators. All are coerced into paying tithes to criminal bands, sometimes the same cartels that run drugs.

“It's a very sensitive crime because of its social impact,” Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum said last week. “It doesn't only affect one person. It affects everyone.”

Sheinbaum launched a

high-profile crackdown against extortion, but her efforts face steep odds. Extortion, experts say, is a multi-billion-dollar racket, perhaps even more lucrative than drug trafficking. It sometimes is called “the invisible crime,” since most victims fail to report threats, fearing retaliation.

Those targeted often confront a ghastly choice: accept ultimatums to hand over cash, property or other assets — or face death, a threat routinely aimed at family members as well.

“Sure, I can say, ‘I won't

[See Extortion, A4]

Hollywood's big new player? Saudi Arabia

The oil-rich kingdom, a pariah not long ago, spends lavishly to entice studios, stars.

By Stacy Perman, August Brown and Samantha Masunaga

Earlier this month, when billionaire tech mogul Larry Ellison needed more money to bolster Paramount's hostile takeover bid for Warner Bros. Discovery, he and his family turned to a lucrative source: Saudi Arabia.

The kingdom's sovereign wealth fund backed a \$24-billion financing package in support of Paramount Skydance's \$78-billion play for Warner, which already had accepted an offer from Netflix for its film and TV studio, HBO and HBO Max.

Less than a week earlier, it was reported the same sovereign fund would scoop up nearly all of Redwood City, Calif.-based gaming giant Electronic Arts in a proposed \$55-billion deal — the biggest leveraged buyout on record.

Saudi Arabia's prominent role in some of the most

consequential Hollywood deals in a generation is just the latest and perhaps the most audacious move by the kingdom to expand its footprint in the U.S. entertainment and sports arenas.

The deals underscore how dramatically Saudi Arabia has changed the narrative from only a few years ago, when it was deemed a pariah by many in Hollywood.

The gruesome murder of journalist Jamal Khashoggi seven years ago did little to dispel the kingdom's image as a repressive theocracy, where beheadings in public squares took place and where, until 2018, women were prohibited from driving and movie theaters were banned.

Suddenly, however, the Saudis — and more specifically their money — are everywhere in the U.S. entertainment industry.

Inside the kingdom's gilded palaces, industry players are mingling with princes and executives, while celebrities stroll red carpets at festivals, concerts and sporting events from Riyadh to Jeddah. Even Comcast Chairman Brian [See Saudi Arabia, A12]



BABBLEJIT KAUR, with two of her children in an undated photo, ran Natraj Cuisine of India for years.

Seeking green card, she was taken by ICE

Longtime Long Beach restaurateur garners support as lawmaker calls for her release.

By Itzel Luna

Babblejit “Bubbly” Kaur and her husband, Amarjit Singh, celebrated their 41st wedding anniversary in Long Beach in late November. The pair cradled a mint-frosted cake in their hands and beamed as their daughter, Joti, snapped pictures.

The couple endured a lot in those years, more than 30 of which have been spent in the U.S., after they fled religious persecution in India.

They arrived in 1994 with three young children and little money, facing a daunting asylum process. But the cou-

ple found their niche, operating a beloved Indian restaurant for decades, and saw their children through college.

This year already had been tough for the family. Singh was diagnosed with cancer and Kaur was laid off from her cashier job at Rite Aid, where she'd worked for decades, after the company closed in October. But the biggest hurdle for the family came only days after the couple's anniversary, on Dec. 1, when Kaur was detained by Immigration and Customs Enforcement during a routine fingerprinting appointment and eventually taken to the Adelanto ICE Processing Center.

Joti Kaur, the couple's youngest daughter, collapsed at work when she heard the news.

[See Detained, A8]

Heart attacks surged after January blazes

By Corinne Purtill

In the first 90 days after the Palisades and Eaton fires erupted in January, the caseload at Cedars-Sinai Medical Center's emergency room looked different from the norm.

There were 46% more visits to the Los Angeles hospital for heart attacks than typically occurred during the same period over the previous seven years. Visits for respiratory illnesses increased 24%. And unusual blood test results rose 118%.

These findings were reported in a study published

Wednesday in the Journal of the American College of Cardiology. The study, part of a research project documenting the fires' long-term health effects, joins several recent papers documenting the disasters' physical toll.

Although other U.S. wildfires have consumed more acres or cost more lives, the Palisades and Eaton fires were uniquely dangerous to human health because they burned an unusual mix of materials: the trees, brush and organic material of a typical wildfire, along with a toxic stew of cars, batteries, plastics, electronics and [See Fires, A8]

A new name for Kennedy Center?

Trump allies vote to add the president's name to the complex, but the legality of the move is unclear. **NATION, A5**

Storm may bring white Christmas

A Pineapple Express atmospheric river system may deliver snow to Sierra, rain to Southland. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Erewhon to open anew after blaze

Fancy grocer will return to Pacific Palisades in a renovated luxury mall owned by developer Rick Caruso. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 70/51. **B6**

